

Mr Loudspeaker

He has a vision for education and the will to reform it. He also has a habit of announcing before implementing.

SIBAL BELIEVES HE HAS STARTED A NATIONAL DEBATE ON EDUCATION

By Kaveree Bamzai

I have now decided to be more careful when speaking to the media," says Kapil Sibal, sitting in his office, one eye on his watch and the other on his cellphone, 24 hours after a nine-day trip to the US that took him to the universities of Harvard, Boston, MIT and Yale. It's typical of the 61-year-old Union Human Resource Development (HRD) minister that he makes a declaration about not making declarations and then retracts it the minute you head for the door. Since taking over one of the most

controversial portfolios in the Cabinet, Sibal, in keeping with the histrionics he learnt at the St Stephen's Shakespeare Society, has shown a taste for the dramatic, and never been far from the newspaper headlines or the television cameras. He's had four formal press conferences and five "informal" interactions in five months. And almost invariably, he has had to follow a declaration with a clarification.

So it was with the announcement of the abolition of CBSE Class X boards, which got publicised as the abolition of all state boards which naturally had state governments up in arms about

not being consulted. So it was with the announcement of a rise in the percentage in Class XII board exams for students who take the entrance examination for IIT, which started off as a statement on the formation of a committee on coaching classes, and then became a full-blown political battle with Nitish Kumar and Mayawati accusing him of elitism. So it was with the The Right of Children to Free and Compulsory Education Bill where he omitted to mention that the states need to spend an additional Rs 60,000 crore—a figure that is even now being debated by the Planning Commission.